

31, called to protest Arvind Kejriwal's arrest. She formed a natural sorority with the Delhi CM's wife Sunita—her commiserations to whom carried a ring of honesty—but it was her own turn as the suffering wife that stole the show even then. Dignified, soft but clear in articulation, winsome and earnest by demeanour, if anything, she's probably proving to have more crossover carry than what her rather more saturnine husband may have managed. Imagine the revolutionary Santhal 'Hul' salutations ringing out on the national stage! Kalpana has also emerged as the pivot for the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha's campaign, including for the assembly polls later this year. With Hemant's WiFi looking to be on the blink for a while, big things likely await Kalpana Soren. Watch this space. ■

Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE

ugged

The dour-faced **Pinarayi Vijayan** is often accused of being from the tribe of demagogues of whom it is said that they 'speak softly but carry a big stick'. So he could use a loudspeaker or two. But the sound systems in Kerala seem to be revolting against the chief minister. Whenever he addresses the public or the media, the mics fail—the gremlins have struck so often that it's become an internet meme by now. Microphones started protesting against Pinarayi in July 2023 when he was speaking at a function to commemorate the late Congress leader Oommen Chandy—as they started howling like wolves, he had to discontinue his speech! An overzealous police even registered a case of suspected sabotage against the microphone operator—Pinarayi intervened to get him off the hook. The 'mike strike' continued, though. On April 6, at a campaign rally in Kottayam, that howl picked up again—cutting into fine polemical words at key junctures. Two days later, it happened again as the CM addressed the press at Adoor, in Pathanamthitta district—so Pinarayi went unplugged. Ditto at a presser in Thrissur. "It seems that the problem occurs only when I speak," he said, smiling. We didn't seek any feedback from the mics. ■



▶ DELHI

Double Teamed

Mahabal Mishra, the 70-year-old Madhubani native, has always had decent traction among the Purvanchali voters who have made the national capital their home. In fact, the INDIA bloc's candidate from West Delhi expresses—in his own curious way—the pooling of votes between the Congress and AAP. He used to be with the Grand Old Party, having even been West Delhi MP in 2009; now he's with AAP. So he ticks the anti-BJP boxes on both sides. Even so, on Ramnavami, he thought it wise to visit the Ram mandir in Ayodhya anyway. ■